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Naya Drishti Ministries

Sola Gratia

Sikkim Theological Journal

After receiving a positive response for the very first issue that we had published last year, we are delighted to present the second issue of the Sikkim Theological Journal. We have chosen *Sola Gratia* as the theme this time.

We are thankful to all the authors who have contributed to this issue by submitting their articles.

The views presented by the authors in the journal are expressly their own and may not completely align with the theological position of Naya Drishti Ministries.

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Editor's Introduction

John Chettri who is a pastor at All Nations Church in Siliguri, in his article explains how the Johannine concept of *Logos* was developed by combining the existing Greek and Jewish philosophies about their respective understanding of the term. John developed his idea on the existing schools of thought and identified and presented Jesus as the divine *Logos* in his gospel account–the Word made flesh and the ultimate source of saving grace, a different kind of grace replacing the Law given through Moses. This grace which comes from his fullness offers salvation and forgiveness of sins. However, as the author has observed, in many Nepali churches today, there are some groups that seem to challenge the fullness and sufficiency of grace by promoting teachings that deem it necessary for believers to observe Jewish festivals and dietary laws. He refutes these ideas by stating that salvation is not attained by the observance of these rituals but by the sufficiency of God's grace alone.

Wungtei Buchem who is an Associate Professor of Biblical Studies, Old Testament at Trinity Theological College, Dimapur exegetes Romans 6:14 to show the

interplay of grace and sin and how grace has the power to liberate us from the tyranny of sin. As some people in the church in Rome had misunderstood grace and regarded it as a license to sin, Paul responds to this by stating emphatically that by the power of God's grace, believers are no longer under the reign of sin as they are ushered into newness of life and liberty from the bondage of sin. Finally, Buchem puts forth his argument that grace has the power to change a person's destiny.

Suraj Kasula who is a pastor at Shekinah Evangelical Church at Bhaktapur in Nepal, recounts the history of how the Reformers redeemed the doctrine of *Sola Gratia* during a time when it had been replaced by a very different doctrine which undermined the sufficiency of grace in its role in a person's salvation. Jesus and the apostles had always taught that works do not contribute in any way in salvation but the Catholic Church had formed their own version in which works and traditions also were considered necessary for salvation. He points out that the doctrine of Sola Gratia has again been under attack in recent times as there have been some active groups going

around preaching that observance of Jewish rituals and festivals are necessary for salvation.

Pravesh Tamang, a scholar from Sikkim, addresses a very concerning problem that is prevalent in India, particularly in Sikkim, namely, drug addiction. Drug addiction has been known to be a disorder that affects the brain. He points out that this is primarily a sin issue as sin corrupts the human will and the affected individual is not in control of his own will. However, when an individual puts his faith in God, he will find that the power of God's grace makes him a new person and that his will has been renewed which gives him hope for recovery. Whereas there are professionals who deal with this medical condition, the author suggests that this is an area where pastors can also step in and help individuals battling this condition on their road to recovery, reminding them of how God's grace can meet us in our weakest condition and give us renewed hope and will.

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The Incarnate Logos as the Ultimate Source of Grace: An Exegetical Reading of the Johannine Prologue and its Implications for Nepali Churches

John Chettri*

Abstract: This article is a philosophical and theological exploration of the identity of Jesus in the Johannine prologue as the incarnate *Logos* and the ultimate source of grace that offers salvation to humanity. Through an exegetical analysis, it emphasizes that the fullness of grace that saves humanity is embodied in Jesus, not in the Mosaic Law. Furthermore, this article contextualizes the theological insight of the prologue within the context of Nepali churches, where the observance of Jewish rituals and festivals appears to undermine the sufficiency of grace. It argues that believers find saving grace not in traditions and rituals, but in Jesus alone.

INTRODUCTION

The concept of *Logos* carries one of the most significant theological themes in the gospel account of John. This term, generally translated as "the Word" serves as a central framework for the Johannine Christological viewpoint in the gospel. John develops his understanding of the *Logos*

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from the already existing diverse philosophical and religious backgrounds of his time, demonstrating that these backgrounds ultimately find their fulfilment in the person of Jesus Christ. Further, by presenting *Logos* as incarnate Jesus with fullness of grace, he extends the identity of Jesus as the ultimate source of grace, who shares grace out of his fullness.

This article undertakes an exegetical exploration of the Johannine prologue, emphasizing particularly on how John presents Jesus Christ as the divine *Logos* in dialogue with the existing traditions and as the ultimate source of grace. The term "grace", another significant term in theological studies, carries various interpretations and theological nuances. Although these interpretations and nuances are valuable, they are out of the purview of this article. This article perceives grace in a standard sense as the unmerited favour of God, through which humanity receives forgiveness of sins and the gift of salvation.

Furthermore, it seeks to examine how the author redefines the source of this salvific grace by contrasting the grace embodied in Christ with the Law given by Moses. Finally, it aims to contextualize its theological

insight within the framework of contemporary Nepali churches, where the observance of Jewish rituals and festivals based on the Law leads to theological confusion regarding the sufficiency of grace in Christ. The ultimate goal of this article is to reaffirm that Jesus alone is the source of saving grace. One does not need to follow additional rituals or any philosophical teachings to attain grace, for it is a gift of God, given from the fullness of Jesus to all who receive him as their personal saviour.

UNDERSTANDING *LOGOS*

The term *Logos* is usually translated as "the Word" in the gospel. However, it renders multiple meanings such as account, collection, speech, to recount, and so on.[1] Due to the various renditions of its meanings, Thomas H. Tobin suggests that the specific meaning of *Logos* depends on the context that it is used in.[2] In the ancient world, *Logos* had different meanings as used by different traditions.

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[1] William F. Arndt, F. Wilbur Gingrich, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and other Early Christian Literature* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1957), 478-79.

[2] Thomas H. Tobin, "Logos," in *The Anchor Bible Dictionary*, ed. David Noel Freedman, Vol. 4 (New York: Doubleday, 1992), 348.

Those traditions likely worked as a background for John to develop his concept of *Logos*. Therefore, it is crucial to briefly explore those backgrounds to grasp the concept of *Logos* in the prologue of John.

1. *Logos* in the Greek world

The term *Logos* was a key technical term in several Greek philosophical systems. Prominent Greek philosophers such as Heraclitus, Plato, and Aristotle and philosophical groups such as the Stoics used the term *Logos* in their philosophies and developed their concepts.[3] Heraclitus used it as a unifying principle that guides the ever-changing world.[4] Whereas, Plato and Aristotle understood *Logos* as true account or rational speech that organizes a human's rational life,[5] the Stoics developed the idea of Plato and Aristotle further and presented *Logos* as

[3] Ronald H. Nash, *The Gospel and the Greeks: Did the New Testament Borrow from Pagan Thought?* (New Jersey: P&R Publishing, 2003), 70.

[4] Craig S. Keener, *The Gospel of John: A Commentary, Vol. 1* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Baker Academic, 2003), 341.

[5] Tobin, "Logos," 348. Cf. Jose Maniparampil, *Reading the Fourth Gospel* (Bangalore: Claretian Publications, 2004), 129.

"reason"—the impersonal rational principle governing the whole universe.[6]

In the ancient Greek world, the perception of *Logos* appears more in a metaphysical sense—an abstract reason or a force guiding the world. However, this perception of *Logos* seems alien to the Johannine *Logos* as John presents *Logos* as a person rather than some abstract principle.

2. *Logos* in Jewish understanding

The Jews primarily understood *Logos* as "the Word of God." The term has some affinity with *memra* of Targum, and *dabar* of the Old Testament, both meaning the creating and self-manifesting "Word of God."[7] This Word

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[6] Andreas J. Kostenberger, *Encountering John: The Gospel in Historical, Literary, and Theological Perspective* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Baker Academic, 1999), 51. For them, *Logos* is the divine reason which originated, permeated, and directed all things. It gives the basis for a rational moral life. Menjiwapong Jamir, *Understanding the Jesus Movement in the Gospel Traditions* (Kolkata: SCEPTRE, 2013), 168.

[7] *Memra*, means "the Word," signifying God's active self-manifestation and his activity in the world. Mary L. Coloe, *God Dwells with Us: Temple Symbolism in the Fourth Gospel* (Minnesota: The Liturgical Press, 2001), 21. In LXX, the Hebrew word *dabar* is often translated as *Logos* in prophetic and wisdom literature, and *Rhema* in the Pentateuch. Biju Chacko, *Intercultural Christology in John's Gospel* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2022), 92.

of God is further viewed as *torah*, the divine law that guides humanity. Moreover, in the prophetic books, phrases like "the Word of the Lord came" also signifies God's self-revelation and communication with humanity through his Word.[8]

The Jews also understood *Logos* as "the personified wisdom of God." This wisdom is personified in Proverbs 8:22-31 and presented as existing before the beginning of the world as a created thing and then being present with God in the rest of the creation.[9] The Wisdom of Solomon 8:22 - 9:18 presents the same wisdom as the creator and moderator of all that exists, who initiates humans into the knowledge of God and brings them into immortality.[10]

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[8] C.H. Dodd, *The Interpretation of the Fourth Gospel* (London: Cambridge University Press, 1963), 263.

[9] George Ladd, *A Theology of the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1974), 240. Some of the other wisdom literature such as Job, Ecclesiastes, Song of Solomon, and other Apocryphal books such as Sirach and Wisdom of Solomon also talk about the wisdom of Proverbs 8. Glenn W. Barker, William L. Lane and Ramsey Michaels, *The New Testament Speaks* (New York: Harper and Row Publishers, 1969), 389.

[10] Ladd, *A Theology of the New Testament*, 240.

Unlike Greek understanding, the Jewish understanding of *Logos* is more theological and personal. This perception of *Logos* appears closer to the Johannine understanding of *Logos*, particularly regarding its personhood and its role in creation and revelation.

3. *Logos* according to Philo

The interpretation of *Logos* according to Philo appears to have had a major influence on Johannine understanding of *Logos*. Some scholars such as Dodd and Benard advocate that the *Logos* of Philo is the background for John's *Logos*.[11] Philo, representing a Hellenistic understanding combined both Greek and Jewish perspectives, presented *Logos* not only as a rational principle but a divine personality.[12] For him, *Logos* was God's first-born Son,[13] "heavenly true man" who is an intermediary between transcendent God and his creation.[14] Philo's perception of

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[11] Keener, *The Gospel of John*, 344.

[12] Mark L. Strauss, *Four Portraits, One Jesus: An Introduction to Jesus and the Gospels* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Zondervan, 2007), 251.

[13] *Πρωτόγονος Υἱός*- who pre-existed with God and functions as an ambassador to humanity and separates creature from the creator. Keener, *The Gospel of* John, 345.

[14] Ladd, *A Theology of the New Testament*, 239.

Logos appears to be similar to the Johannine *Logos* to some extent. However, it seems to assume some unidentified divine creature to be the *Logos*, rather than identifying Jesus as the divine *Logos*.

4. *Logos* according to John

Considering these diverse backgrounds, it becomes plain that John developed the concept of *Logos* from a rich blend of Greek and Jewish philosophical and theological traditions. Although various interpretations of *Logos* were already existing, John goes beyond these backgrounds to present the identification of Jesus as the divine *Logos* in the prologue. He presents *Logos* as a Christological title depicting the identity and role of Jesus, the Son of God.[15] Although John explicitly reveals *Logos* as the identity of Jesus only in verse 14, the entire argument of the prologue and the presentation of *Logos* is grounded in this identification, portraying *Logos* as Jesus, the incarnate Son of God.

[15] T. G. Donner, "Logos," in *IVP New Dictionary of Theology*, eds. Sinclair B. Furguson and David F. Wright (England: Inter-Varsity Press, 1988), 395-396.

Some theological views of *Logos* in the Johannine prologue are explored below:

4.1. *Logos* as eternal and divine (1:1)

The opening verse of the prologue affirms the eternal and divine nature of *Logos*. In John 1:1, the phrase "In the beginning was the Word" indicates its existence before anything else of the creation.[16] The following phrase "the Word was with God" indicates that *Logos*, being with God from the beginning, was eternally pre-existent like God, sharing God's eternity.[17] Not only did *Logos* exist in the beginning, but he existed in the closest possible connection with God the Father.[18] The phrase "was with God" expresses the personal existence of the *Logos* and his intimate relationship with God.[19]

By introducing *Logos* "himself as God", John thus affirms not only the pre-existence but also the divinity of

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[16] Leon Morris, *The Gospel According to John* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1995),

[17] Bruce Milne, *The Message of John* (England: InterVarsity Press, 1993), 32.

[18] Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, 68.

[19] Later in verse 18, this relationship is expressed in an intimate Father-Son relationship depicting the relation between God and Jesus.

Logos as God. Morris states, "John is not merely saying that there is something divine about *Logos*, he is affirming that he is God."[20] Since John is presenting the *Logos* as the identity of Jesus (1:14), this phrase functions as a strong evidence of the truth that Jesus is God—one of the three persons of the Trinity under the Godhead of the Father.

4.2. *Logos* as the creator and life-giver (1:1-5)

If *Logos* is God himself, it is natural that he is the creator and giver of life to all. The phrase "In the beginning" echoing Genesis 1:1, links the *Logos* to God and the act of creation, establishing him as an active agent of creation.[21] The third verse confirms it as John writes, "all things were made through him and without him was not any thing made that was made."

The following verse depicts him as the source of life as it says, "In him was life, and the life was the light

[20] Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, 69.

[21] The Greek word for "beginning," *ἀρχή*, meaning "origin," suggests that *Logos*—already present at the world's beginning—is portrayed as the creator or originator of all things. D.A. Carson, *The Gospel According to John* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1991), 114.

of men" (John 1:4). It is important to note that the use of the word *ζωὴ* for life signifies more than mere existence, it represents salvation and eternal life (John 3:36).[22] Further, John identifies this life with the light. Throughout the gospel, both light and eternal life are attributed to Jesus.[23] Carson believes, that both light and life refer to salvation. Light is the revelation of God in Jesus which people may receive and in faith be saved into eternal life.[24] By attributing light and eternal life to *Logos*, John is indicating that this *Logos* is none other than Jesus, who is the creator, the light of the world, and the giver of eternal life.

4.3. *Logos* made flesh (1:14)

The climax of the entire presentation of the prologue is found in verse 14, as he portrays *Logos* as becoming flesh

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[22] Robert Kysar, "John," in *Augsburg Commentary on the New Testament* (Minneapolis: Augsburg Publishing House, 1986), 30.

[23] Jesus is depicted as sent by God to offer eternal life (3:16; 5:24). Jesus himself affirms, "I am the life" (14:6), and declares, "I have come that they may have life, and have it abundantly" (10:10). John also presents Jesus as the Light of the world. Jesus himself says that he is the light of the world and whoever follows him would receive the light of life (John 8:12; 9:5).

[24] Carson, *The Gospel According to John*, 119.

and dwelling among humans. Unlike Philo, the Johannine *Logos* did not merely manifest as a ghost, but it literally became a human and dwelled among humans.[25] It was Jesus, the Son of God who took the form of a human and tabernacled among humans.

The verb *ἐσκήνωσεν* which means tabernacled, evokes the Old Testament image of God's presence among the Israelites in the wilderness when the Israelites had built the tabernacle as the place of worship and the glory of the Lord filled the tabernacle (Ex. 40:34-35).[26] John suggests that God has now come to dwell with his people through Jesus in an even closer, more personal way than his presence in the tabernacle during the Exodus (Ex. 40:34-35).[27]

In John 1:1-14, John presents the *Logos* as a profound Christological title. Engaging with the existing traditions concerning the *Logos*, he argues that if the *Logos* is the power that guides the world, the wisdom of

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[25] Andreas, J. Kostenberger, *John: Baker Exegetical Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, Michigan: Baker Academic, 2004), 41.

[26] Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, 114.

[27] Chacko, *Intercultural Christology in John's Gospel*, 160.

God that creates and sustains everything or the heavenly being who mediates between God and humanity, then this *Logos* is none other than Jesus—the incarnate Son of God, the creator and sustainer of all, who took on human form and dwelled among humanity to grant them eternal life.

4.4. *Logos* as the source of grace (1:14-18)

In the latter section of the prologue, John expands the concept of the *Logos* by identifying it as the source of grace (1:14,17).

The term **"grace"** holds a significant place in Christian theology, yet it has been interpreted in various ways. In contemporary Christian thought, grace is often perceived merely as divine assistance that enables individuals to achieve success or material prosperity. However, such an understanding significantly narrows the biblical meaning of grace. In the biblical context, grace is fundamentally rooted in the recognition of human's sinful condition and God's undeserved favour towards humanity. It denotes God's initiative in forgiving sins and granting salvation, not as a response to human merit or achievement but as a manifestation of divine love and mercy.

The New Testament employs the Greek term *xaris* for grace which is generally translated as the unmerited favour of God towards humanity.[28] This grace closely corresponds with the Hebrew word *hesed* which primarily emphasizes God's steadfast love and mercy,[29] while depicting the idea of God graciously turning towards his suffering people to offer help.[30] In the Pauline literature, it appears around 110 times, closely connecting with the idea of *hesed* with the central idea of divine grace, in which God shows mercy by not judging humans for their sinfulness and saves them by forgiving their sins through Christ.[31] In his gospel account, the evangelist uses grace only three times in the prologue, emphasizing its divine source.[32] He presents Jesus, the Incarnate *Logos* as the ultimate source of divine grace.

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[28] Ken Mulzac, "Grace in the Synoptic Teaching of Jesus," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, Vol. 14, No. 2 (2003): 66.

[29] Gary S. Shogren, "Grace," in *The Anchor Yale Bible Dictionary*, ed. David Noel Freedman Vol. 2 (Yale University Press: USA, 2008), 1086-87.

[30] Mulzac, "Grace in the Synoptic Teaching of Jesus," 67.

[31] Mulzac, "Grace in the Synoptic Teaching of Jesus," 67.

[32] Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, 116.

According to verse 14, *Logos* became flesh being "full of grace and truth." This phrase appears to echo the Hebrew word pair *hesed, we'emet*' (Ex. 34:6), which expresses God's steadfast love and faithfulness even in the midst of the sinfulness of the Israelites.[33] In this passage, after revealing his glory to Moses, God passes by and proclaims, "The LORD, the LORD, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness". Notably, this forgiving steadfast love of God is revealed in the context of the Israelites' sin of worshipping a golden idol (Ex. 32:34). According to Collin G. Cruse, by equating *xaris* with *hesed*, John demonstrates that the steadfast love and faithfulness, which comprised the glory of God revealed to Moses, are now present in the Incarnate *Logos*.[34] Thus, God's steadfast love and unmerited favour that forgives and

[33] Gail R. O'Day, "The Gospel of John" in *The New Interpreter's Bible*, ed. Leander E. Keck, Vol. 9 (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1995), 523.

[34] Collin G. Cruse, "John: An Introduction and Commentary," in *Tyndale New Testament Commentaries*, ed. Leon Morris, Vol. 4 (Illinois: Intervarsity Press, 2003), 70.

saves humanity from sinfulness is embodied in Jesus, the Incarnate *Logos.*

Furthermore, John writes, "for from his fullness we have all received, grace upon grace" (1:16). This statement continues the thought of verse 14, where John writes about the Word becoming flesh, full of grace and truth. However, this verse shifts the emphasis from "seeing" the grace to "receiving" the grace out of his fullness.[35] John employs the same verb for "receiving" here as he does in verse 12, where he speaks about receiving Jesus.[36] This linguistic connection indicates that those who have received Jesus have already received grace out of his fullness.

GRACE INSTEAD OF THE MOSAIC LAW

The use of the phrase *xarin anti xaritos* indicates a unique, yet an interesting nuance to the idea of grace. Generally, the phrase is translated as "grace upon grace," signifying a continuous flow of graces, one after another.[37] However,

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[35]Cruse, "John: An Introduction and Commentary," 73.

[36] Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, 118.

[37] Rudolf Schnackenburg, *The Gospel According to Saint John*, trans. Kevin Smith, Vol. 1 (Great Britain: Burns &Oates, 1968), 275.

the use of the preposition *anti* may literally render the phrase "grace instead of grace" signifying a new grace replacing the old. Carson suggests, the most convincing translation of this phrase is "grace instead of grace," indicating that from Christ's fullness, we have all received the grace instead of grace.[38] However, this raises a question: which grace is the grace of Christ replacing?

The next verse may solve this question as it says, "for the law was given through Moses; grace and truth came through Jesus Christ" (v17). Based on this statement, the grace and truth that came from Christ is what replaces the Law given by Moses. Carson agrees with this as he thinks that the Law itself was understood to be the earlier display of grace.[39] A good deal of Jewish thought regards grace and truth as two attributes of God revealed by Moses through the Law. John may well be

[38] Carson suggests four options for translating the preposition *anti*: (a) "Corresponds to," indicating that the grace Christian receives in some sense corresponds to the grace of Christ; (b) grace "in return for," indicating one grace is given in return for another; (c) "upon or addition to" ;(d) grace "instead of" indicating that from the fulness of Christ we have received the grace instead of grace. The fourth one is the most convincing translation for this phrase. Carson, *The Gospel According to John*, 104.

[39] Carson, *The Gospel According to John*, 107.

trying to clarify that they are wrongly ascribed to Moses. They came through Jesus, not through Moses. As for the association of truth in the phrase, Morris opines, the truth was certainly revealed by the Law given through Moses, but John's concern is with the whole way of salvation by grace as it was revealed and established in the ministry of Jesus.[40]

However, it does not imply that John is totally rejecting the Law and substituting it with the grace of Jesus. As Schnackenburg observes, John uses the term law to designate Scripture as a source of revelation (1:45; 8:17; 10:34). His disassociation from the Law parallels to his treatment of other Jewish cults (4:21-24) and their legalistic interpretation of the Law that undermined the fullness and sufficiency of the grace of Jesus and insisted to observe various Jewish rituals (2:6; 3:25; 11:55; 19:40), and celebrate Jewish festivals (2:13; 5:1; 6:4; 7:2). He regarded such laws as obsolete and no longer important in receiving the grace that brings forgiveness and salvation.[41]

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[40] Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, 119.
[41] Schnackenburg, *The Gospel According to St John*, 278.

This has to be understood in the context of the Second Temple Period where Jews made the Law as their national identity marker and claimed that those who observe the Jewish rituals and traditions mentioned in the Law are the only elect people of God and the recipients of grace and salvation. Based on this claim, they excluded Gentiles out from God's covenant of grace.[42] The apostle Paul explicitly confronts this problem in his letters (Gal. 4:9-11; Col. 2:16-17). In Colossians, Paul identifies these rituals and festivals of the Law as merely a shadow of the reality that is found in Christ. Similarly, John may be implying that the Law given by Moses represents just a shadow of the grace whereas, the fullness of grace is found in Christ. This further implies that believers are no longer required to observe the additional rituals of the Law. They have received the grace of God, which grants them forgiveness of sins and salvation through the fullness of God's grace embodied in Jesus Christ.

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[42] James D.G. Dunn, *The Epistles to the Colossians and to Philemon, The New International Greek New Testament Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996), 154.

IMPLICATION

Churches in Darjeeling and Sikkim are exposed to a diversity of teachings due to the presence of various denominations and movements. Out of those movements, some appear to be promoting teachings that challenge Christ's sovereignty and his fullness. It is generally noticed that certain groups advocate that apart from receiving Christ, churches must observe Jewish rituals and festivals for attaining divine grace. They appear to insist the churches to observe certain Jewish festivals that Paul forbids, such as the Feast of Tabernacles, Rosh Hashannah, and so on with the argument that these festivals should still be observed by believers.[43] However, the Bible gives ample reasons that the purpose of these festivals is already fulfilled in Christ.

For instance, the tabernacle served as the place where God dwelt and communicated with his people, demonstrating how a sinful person could approach and worship a holy God (Ex. 29:42–43). It represented the

[43] Solomon Rai, "Part 2 NCCUK & Joshua Himalaya Question & Answer Meeting Part 2 of 3" NCCUK Official, YouTube Video, 1:00:43, 25 November, 2024, https://youtu.be/Ge8GyATjp_8.

redemptive grace of God toward his people.[44] However, Jesus, the Divine *Logos* has already become the fulfilment of the Old Testament tabernacle as he came to the world and permanently tabernacled among us (1:14). In him, the purpose of the tabernacle has been realized, for he reveals God (John 1:18) and through him, believers become the children of God (John 1:12). This implies that, in Christ, believers are no longer bound by the observance of the Feast of Tabernacles, since its significance has already been fulfilled in Christ.

Similarly, some Nepali churches appear to be confused regarding the observance of certain Jewish rituals, such as dietary laws. The law concerning the consumption of a specific meat has created a significant controversy among the churches. However, the statement, "the law was given by Moses but grace and truth came through Jesus Christ" may serve as a clear guide to the churches signifying that the saving grace of God is not dependent on the observance of Jewish dietary laws.

[44] David M. Levy, *The Tabernacle: Shadows of the Messiah, Its Sacrifice, Services, and Priesthood* (Bellmawr, NJ: The Friends of Israel Gospel Ministry, 2017), 16-17.

Rather, it is received through faith in Jesus Christ as one's personal saviour. This implies, believers are no longer obligated to practice such laws in order to attain the salvific grace of God. It is a gift of God, received from the fullness of Jesus, when one receives him as the Saviour of his life.

CONCLUSION

The prologue of the gospel of John intensely identifies Jesus as the Divine *Logos* and the ultimate source of saving grace. By engaging with the existing traditions, John refutes the idea of *Logos* as merely reason or creative wisdom and presents it as the person of Jesus Christ who reveals God, shares grace, and imparts eternal life from his fullness. The contrast between the Mosaic Law and grace of Jesus signifies that the fullness of saving grace is found in Jesus alone. For the Nepali churches, the Johannine prologue reaffirms that grace and salvation are not attained through the observance of rituals and festivals based on the Law. Rather, it is received through faith in Jesus, the incarnate *Logos*. He alone is the source of God's saving grace and his grace is sufficient for all who receive him.

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Sola Gratia Surpasses the Consequences of Sin: Reading Paul's Theology of Grace in Romans 6:14

Wungtei Buchem*

INTRODUCTION

In some versions of the Bible, the word "grace" occurs 21 times in 18 verses in the book of Romans. The concept undergirds almost all of Paul's theological thinking throughout the entire letter to the Romans. Paul's explanation of the gospel in Romans is centered by his own personal understanding of God's grace (Rom. 1:5). He had first received it himself and now he has rethought everything in light of his own personal transformation. He then preaches that the grace that is received ought to be shared. This article is prompted by the biblical fact about sin and its consequences which is a predominant theme throughout the Bible. By virtue of the consequences set, "the wages of sin is death" (Rom. 6:23)—a retribution or in other words, the consequences of sin are inevitable.

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However, I argue from the Pauline point of view in agreement with my personal conviction that the grace of God is sovereign over the imagined consequences of sin. In the discussion below, I will lay down Paul's theology of sin and grace specifically in Romans and exegete to show how the grace of God supersedes the curse of sin.

PAUL'S THEOLOGY OF GRACE IN THE BOOK OF ROMANS

From Paul's consistent opening formula in 1:7 ("Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ") through his closing doxology in 16:20 ("The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you"), his letter to the church situated in Rome is stamped from front to back with thoughts of grace. This is consistent with Paul's conversion and his understanding of God. Where would Paul have been without God's intervention on his way to Damascus? He says later in 1 Corinthians that it is "by the grace of God, I am what I am" (v15:10).

This deeply personal understanding of grace stands behind Paul's exposition of God's rescue of the human race through Jesus. Paul knew what it was like to be under sin—falling short of the glory of God (v3:23).

He knew what it was like to miss the all too important message of Jesus and his teachings. He later knew what kind of peace with God comes as a result of being reconciled with God (v5:1 and v5:10). The grace of God, embodied in the death of Christ on the cross, demands a response from believers. The gift is surely free and cannot be earned through meritorious work. However, grace compels believers to a new way of living, Christ having defeated sin victoriously on the cross.

Paul felt that this grace which he knew from his study and his experience had real and practical implications for the way he should now live. In Romans 1:14, he says that he is "under obligation" to preach the gospel to anyone who will listen because of what God has done for him. This "obligation of grace," as we might call it, is an important theological point for Paul in all of his letters, but particularly in Romans. Paul was evidently slandered by others for teaching about God's grace, because they misunderstood him to be teaching that people could do evil because God is so gracious (v3:8). A critical point of the letter to the Romans is v6:2, where Paul definitively states, "How shall we who died to sin

still live in it?" God's grace is good and efficacious, but it is no reason for us to dive headlong into sin. This is so important to Paul that he speaks of two "reigns" over the human race: the "reign" of sin and the "reign" of grace (v5:21).

PAUL'S THEOLOGY OF SIN IN THE BOOK OF ROMANS

Paul's theology of sin in the book of Romans is one of the most profound expositions of the human condition and divine grace in the New Testament. For Paul, sin is not merely the commission of immoral acts but a universal power that corrupts, enslaves, and separates humanity from God. In Romans v1:18 to v3:23, Paul establishes the universality of sin: both Gentiles and Jews are under its dominion. The Gentiles, despite the revelation of God in creation, have suppressed the truth and turned to idolatry (Rom. 1:18-32), while the Jews, though possessing the Law, have failed to fulfill its righteous demands (Rom. 2:17-29). Hence, Paul concludes that "all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (Rom. 3:23).

Paul personifies sin as a dominating power in Romans 5-6. Through the disobedience of Adam, sin

entered the world and brought death to all (Rom. 5:12). Humanity thus lives under the reign of sin, which enslaves and leads to death. Yet through Christ, the new Adam, grace and righteousness abound to many, offering a new reign of life (Rom. 5:15-21). As James Dunn (1988) observes, Paul shifts the concept of sin from individual moral failure to a cosmic power that exercises dominion until broken by Christ's redemptive act. Consequently, believers are urged to reckon themselves "dead to sin but alive to God in Christ Jesus" (Rom. 6:11).

In Romans 7, Paul turns to the paradoxical role of the Law. While the Law itself is holy, it exposes the depth of human sinfulness and renders people conscious of their inability to obey. Sin, Paul says, "seizing the opportunity afforded by the commandment, produced in me every kind of coveting" (Rom. 7:8). The Law thus reveals sin but cannot liberate anyone from it. Paul's cry, "Who will rescue me from this body of death?" is answered with "Thanks be to God, through Jesus Christ our Lord!" (Rom. 7:24-25).

Romans 8 marks the climax of Paul's theology of

sin: liberation through the Spirit. The "law of the Spirit of life" has set believers free from the "law of sin and death" (Rom. 8:2). Through the indwelling Spirit, believers participate in Christ's victory and are empowered to live righteously. As N.T. Wright (2002) notes, the Spirit's work not only reverses the effects of sin but inaugurates a new creation within the believer.

THE INTERPLAY OF GRACE AND SIN IN PAUL'S THEOLOGY

The epistle to the Romans stands as Paul's most systematic theological treatise, offering a profound reflection on humanity's fallen state and God's redemptive initiative. Central to Paul's message is the dramatic contrast between sin and grace, two opposing forces that define the human predicament and God's saving act. For Paul, sin is the universal power that enslaves humanity, while grace is the divine gift that liberates and transforms. The interplay between these two realities reveals Paul's understanding of salvation as both an act of divine justice and a manifestation of divine love. Paul's theology is therefore marked by a deliberate tension between the depth of human sin and the

superabundance of divine grace. Romans 5:20 encapsulates this relationship: “Where sin increased, grace increased all the more.” Paul emphasizes that grace does not ignore sin but conquers it. The Law, while exposing sin, could not save; instead, it highlighted humanity’s need for grace (Rom. 7:7-13). Grace accomplishes what the Law could not: liberation from the tyranny of sin and restoration to right relationship with God.

In this radical opposition, sin represents humanity’s rebellion, corruption, and bondage whereas, grace embodies God’s righteousness, mercy, and liberation. Through Christ’s obedience and the Spirit’s renewing work, grace triumphs over sin’s dominion, transforming condemnation into justification and death into life. Paul’s theology thus proclaims that where sin once reigned, grace now rules, revealing not only the seriousness of human depravity but also the immeasurable depth of divine love.

However, Paul rejects any notion that grace encourages moral laxity. In Romans 6:1-2, he asks, “Are we to continue in sin that grace may abound? By no

means!" Grace demands a new ethical response. Those who have died to sin through baptism now live to God in righteousness. As N.T. Wright (2002) notes, Paul's vision of grace inaugurates a new creation, one in which believers are empowered to embody the obedience of faith that sin once made impossible.

HISTORY & BACKGROUND OF PAUL'S LETTER TO THE ROMANS

The earliest manuscript of the Book of Romans is dated around the third century. This book was named after the City of Rome, which is located next to the Tiber River which is twenty miles from the center of Italy. It was like all the other cities in the area but through name recognition as the capital of the Roman Empire and the large population of people, it became the center for trade in the region. With this in mind, it is clear to see why it had a large Christian house church, which was the recipient of this letter written by the apostle Paul most likely in A.D. 56. In the following centuries, this sixteen-chapter letter later became known as the book of Romans. This letter addresses major Christian doctrine affecting the church at that time.

Paul knew that many philosophies that were prevalent in and around the region during that time were trying to infiltrate the church. The church members needed clarification of proper Christian doctrine in order to counter the influence of Platonism, which later formed the foundation of Gnosticism and Roman polytheism. Paul knew, if these philosophies had a chance to influence the church away from true Christian doctrine, the church would not survive or grow into the church he had envisioned. During this period, many of the believers in the church had at one time in their lives probably accepted the Platonic philosophy or Roman polytheism before accepting Jesus Christ as God and the Savior of their lives. Paul wanted to make sure that they knew exactly what the true religious system ("The Way") was and how it would affect their view of God, the world, and their relationships with one another.

EXEGESIS OF ROMANS 6: 14

Before beginning the interpretation, it is important to get the correct context of the scripture just before and after the chosen text. In Romans 6:1-5, Paul begins by stating that the believer should not continue in sin since Jesus

Christ provided the great gift of grace to all who believe. The believer is supposed to be dead to sin and is not to live for its passions manifested through the flesh any longer. The baptism of a believer in Jesus Christ through association makes him a part of his death and resurrection. Thus, believers are given a newness of life and must walk in it.

Paul clearly reveals that a transformation has taken place in a believer's being by the finished work of Jesus Christ through his death, burial, and resurrection. He begins to explain this transformation by making reference to "our old self being crucified with him". This figure of speech refers to the prior fleshly behavior exhibited by believers before knowing Christ (v6). The sinless Christ, being fully human and fully God, crucified our old self along with its control of sin on a believer's life. Being united with Christ, a believer's old self is considered dead and he is not to continue to serve sin. Paul has already referred to the association of the death of Christ with the believer. Now he explains, "We believe that we shall also live with him". The believer is now looking forward to the

future resurrection of their body by Christ because of his finished work on the cross (vv8-9). Paul again points back to the finished work of Christ dying to sin for the last time, which compels and empowers the believer to live for God (v10). Since Christ paid such a high price for sin by the shedding of his blood and broke its control over their lives, the believer's attitude should be—they should no longer live in it (v11). He then explains that sin should not "reign" in the body of a believer to obey its evil behaviors (v12). Their body members are not instruments of unrighteousness to sin but instruments of righteousness unto God because of this transformation instituted by Christ (v13).

Finally, "sin shall not have dominion" over the believer for they are not under the law but grace (v14). In Romans 6:15-23, Paul begins to explain that this freedom from sin and the gift of grace do not give anyone a license to partake in living a sinful life according to the flesh. He gives a strict warning, "God forbid". There is a decision that a believer must make whether to obey sin or obey God. Trusting that the reader will make the right choice, Paul asserts that all will choose to be servants of God's

doctrine contained in the earlier chapters of his letter. He then again reemphasizes the freedom from sin and that all believers are to become servants of righteousness. Knowing that some believers had already fallen into obeying the old self that still has the sinful nature waging war against their spirit, he exhorts them to yield their body members to righteousness unto holiness of life. He again reminds them of their former way of life. Now, that all believers are free from sin, they are to become servants of God exhibiting holiness and when this earthly life is over, they can go on to receive eternal life.

TEXT LITERAL ANALYSIS

[14] For sin shall not have dominion over you, for you are not under law but under grace.

This verse has two "for" clauses. The first "for" declares that the lordship of sin over Christians has ended. The second "for" shows the reason why the lordship of sin is over. We are not under the legal principle of the Law, which demands duty, but under grace that confers God's unconditional blessing.

[14a] for

v14 is the ground for all the statements in verses 11 to 13. Sin's domination is broken through the death and resurrection of Christ. This is the reason for the previous exhortation to present or yield ourselves to God because sin no longer has dominion over Christians, we are free to live under God's blessings.

sin shall not have dominion [*lordship*] **over you,**

The future tense here is a logical progression—this is a promise of victory over sin arising out of an epoch dominated by grace, the epoch of grace. Jesus fulfilled the law in every respect. Sin is an alien power in the epoch of grace.

14b for

This "for" shows the reason sin's domination over the believer is broken. Christians are no longer under the era dominated by Adam or the Mosaic Law but under the epoch of grace. This flies in the face of those who say grace is the basis for licentiousness (Rom. 6:1). On the contrary, grace is the basis for triumph over sin. Paul raised this question again in the next verse (v15). You are not under [the authority of] law.

Those under the epoch of grace no longer owe

allegiance to the epoch of the law. The "law" here is the Mosaic law. That law no longer has the right to exercise authority over the believer under grace. The issue is not about behaving under the law but believing in the law that was fulfilled in Jesus. Behaving will follow believing because of the effect of God's grace on the life of the believer.

SOLA GRATIA SURPASSES THE CURSE OF SIN

Sola Gratia does not mean that we must sin because the grace of God wins over the curse of sin. With some affirming passages such as Romans 5: 20 reading with similar ones in John 1: 17 and Galatians 3: 24-25, believers are justified, or in other words, made righteous not by works but by grace alone. This is the redemption and this is the unmerited privilege given. However, that does not free us from the possible wrath and retribution from God for our sins. Each act of sinfulness follows God's punishment and the consequences can be real. When Paul emphasized God's grace as sovereign, he did not ignore the reality that the wages of sin is death. It does mean that the consequence of sin is inevitable.

How do I know that the wages of my own sin is bought by the grace abounding? How do we realize more of God's grace in our lives? Grace makes it possible for us to be secured from shame, guilt, and our sinful ways of life. The way that we realize more of God's amazing ability and what he wants to do in our lives, is by acknowledging more of his grace in our lives.

Grace is central to Paul's explanation of the gospel and forms the core of God's communication to believers. In Paul's theology, grace surpasses retribution because God's unmerited favor overcomes the just consequences of human sin. While sin earns death as its rightful "wage", grace offers life freely through Christ, not because humanity deserves it, but because God's love and mercy are greater than judgment. Grace does not negate the reality of sin or its seriousness, rather, it enters into the place of retribution, transforming what would have been condemnation into forgiveness, restoration, and empowerment for righteous living. Thus, where sin brings death and separation, grace extends life and reconciliation, demonstrating that God's redemptive

initiative surpasses any human failing or penalty.

The nature of grace is that God acts freely, according to his nature. He has no obligation to fulfill; grace is therefore uncaused in the recipient and the cause is wholly in the giver. The believer's place is "in Christ," which gives us eternal standing before God. The Christian, therefore, is not under probation. God never withdraws his grace. God never accepts us conditionally. God does what he does eternally. God never leaves eternal issues to feeble men. Grace is man's only hope because God never withdraws his grace. The believer is never under the law as a condition of acceptance with God. Grace enables the believer to be entirely acceptable to God.

The concept of grace originates in God's own nature and is uncaused in the recipient. The cause lies in God, not in the recipient. Therefore, any system of human work dishonors God. Grace alone inclines the believer toward God. Grace does not owe anyone anything; there is no obligation it has to pay. That is why grace does not act where it rests on man's efforts. No cause in man causes

God to give his grace. It is humbling to find that our acceptance to God rests on something other than who or what we are.

CONCLUDING APPRAISAL: IT IS *SOLA GRATIA* NOT HUMAN FRAILTY

Human frailty refers to the inherent physical, moral, or psychological weaknesses and vulnerabilities common to people, encompassing aspects like physical weakness, emotional instability, and a tendency towards error, ignorance, or greed. It describes human vulnerability and susceptibility, highlighting the general human condition of imperfection and the inability to fully meet one's own high standards or avoid mistakes and negative behaviors. In other words, the term, human frailty broadly describes the limitations and imperfections that define the human experience. It acknowledges our susceptibility to physical decline, our tendency to make mistakes, and our struggle to consistently uphold our own ideals.

Likewise, despite the clarity of Paul's words "the wages of sin is death" (Rom. 6: 23), I have always wondered if God can change the destiny (the

consequences) of a person's frailty and sin? In my informal discussions with a colleague and others, I have learned that the majority believe that the grace of God cannot cancel the consequences or earthly punishment, however, grace delivers us from eternal condemnation and that, the grace of God grants us forgiveness, redeems, and transforms us although we are not spared from punishment. What one senior ordained minister L. Among Phom says is weighty,

> There is grace greater than our sins. Any sin has great weight. The wages of unforgiving sins bring death. God never curses anyone just at random. If a man is cursed by God, then there is no remedy. I believe there is no grace beyond curse. The curse has end in itself.

What is intriguing about what Phom says is the phrase, "I believe there is no grace beyond curse. The curse has end in itself." How do we understand this? Perhaps, the idea is that if one is cursed, that is the end of everything, meaning that there is no realm of grace beyond what is being cursed. If the grace of God so applies actively and profoundly, it exists prior to being cursed. Therefore, ultimately the grace applies actively in

the context when human can be forgiven, in the moment when human can be made justified, in the situation when he can be made righteous. That would mean, grace is abiding and present even at the point in time when a human deserves to be cursed, yet not cursed but grace surpasses the punishment or curse. In this layer of my thought, the theology of "the finished work of Christ on the cross" applies to only those who believe themselves are justified especially in the realm of souls being justified. As a matter of fact, the unconditional grace keeps even the ones who do not believe in the grace of Jesus on the cross guarded by it. Therefore, what I believe is that the unmerited grace of God illuminated on the cross adds to the reality of God's salvific acts extended to everyone both body and soul of humankind.

Paul's emphasis on the grace of God is paramount. Paul is careful enough to incorporate the message of sin and its consequences lest believers might take advantage of the free gift of grace. While there is an interplay between the two themes of grace and sin, what gives this article a conviction for further thought is the surpassing

power of the grace of God—the unmerited justification of a sinner from penalty, both spiritual and physical. So, in this paradigmatic reading, I have the proposition that God supersedes those awful consequences and can change human destiny. This disposition is solely at the mercy of God, his will, and his purpose for a person's life. While the heart and the intention of God cannot be fathomed, yet God's grace is an experiential phenomenon that a believer encounters in one's walk with God. This is when I call the unmerited grace of God that surpasses or applies beyond the consequences of sin.

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Restoration of the Doctrine of Sola Gratia during the Reformation Era

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Abstract: The doctrine of *Sola Gratia*, which was clearly taught and preached by Jesus and his apostles was sought to be destroyed by the Catholic Church. This unmerited and unearned grace, anchored solely in the person and work of Christ is the sole cause and source of salvation. The great Reformers fought to revive this biblical doctrine over against the Catholic Church who sought to add their human teachings and practices to the divine grace. In this way, the Reformation Revolution not only rediscovered this profound doctrine but also preserved it from corruption, which has now been passed down to the faithful church of Christ, which is a blessing for Nepali churches also across the world.

INTRODUCTION

A tiny little thought becomes a principle and when the principle is embraced by society, it takes the shape of tradition. The tradition then becomes law and is codified in the constitution. This is true in politics, philosophy, law, and even in religion. This is exactly what happened

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in the Pre-Reformation Catholic Church. Traditions outweighed the truth of the Bible. Consequently, the church enshrined countless manmade doctrines and practices, which were blindly dogmatised by the church councils. The Medieval Ages were indeed made the Dark Ages by the Catholic doctrines, as J.C. Ryle observes, "Romanism is a gigantic system of Church worship, sacrament worship, Mary worship, saint worship, image worship, relic worship, and priest worship! In one word, Romanism is a huge organized idolatry."[1]

The Church of Rome controlled the state, those who spoke against their traditions were condemned as heretics and traitors and even burnt at the stake. The human traditions of the Catholic Church not only strangled the biblical doctrine of grace but also mixed them into the divine grace to make an unholy cocktail. The great heroes of the Reformation redeemed the doctrine of grace from the evil dungeon of the Catholic Church. They redefined the doctrine of grace as *Sola Gratia*!

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[1] John Charles Ryle, *Knots United*, ed. G. E. Duffield (Cambridge: James Clarke & Co., 1977), 323.

THE MEANING OF GRACE

Grace is a free gift to an undeserving sinner who can never earn or merit it by his deeds. In Hebrew, the word *rakhum* (רַחוּם) conveys the idea of grace or compassion. Its root word is related to "womb", which evokes a powerful image of deep, nurturing care similar to that of a mother who keeps her child lovingly in her womb. It emphasizes the deep emotional and nurturing aspects of compassionate grace to describe the relationship between God and humanity. The mother plays various roles to keep her baby safe, sound, and warm while the baby enjoys the gift of life and love in the womb. The deep meaning of *Sola Gratia* is conveyed by this powerful example: God does everything for our salvation and we merely enjoy the gift of salvation. We do nothing, but God does everything!

HISTORY OF SOLA GRATIA BEFORE REFORMATION

The doctrine of Sola Gratia dominated the church from the Apostolic Period to the time of Augustine of Hippo. Christ and his apostles clearly taught the doctrine of grace alone. In the parable of the tax collector and the Pharisee, Christ

taught that divine grace is unearned and unmerited which does not depend on human will and deeds but is freely granted to a sinner as a sheer gift of God (Lk. 18:9-14). The paradox is clear: the so-called "religious" Pharisee remained guilty because of his self-righteous haughty heart while the tax collector, a sinner went home as declared righteous by God himself because of his contrite heart. The one who sought to be righteous by the work of the law remained unrighteous while the one who had no righteous work of the law at all received the grace of righteousness. The whole point of Jesus is that grace is granted to an underserved sinner and the one who depends on his good deeds remains graceless forever. The one who does not receive salvation purely through grace, independently of all good works, certainly will never secure it.

Paul and his apostles followed the same teachings of Christ. Paul contended that grace would be meaningless and would not be grace at all if the works of the law could earn or merit it. Rather, it would be the merits of human will and power as Paul writes, "Now to the one who works, his wages are not counted as a gift but as his due"

(Rom. 4:4). Paul clearly said that salvation is purely by the grace of God through faith and not by the works of the law (Eph. 2:8). One would surely boast if it were possible to earn or merit grace by his deeds (Eph. 2:9). But Paul's argument proved that this space of boasting is shut down because salvation is of the Lord (Ps. 62:1). Paul further substantiated his arguments by taking his readers back to the Father of faith, Abraham. Abraham was counted righteous by his faith hundreds of years before circumcision and the Law were given to Israel (Gen. 15:6, Rom. 4:3).

The teachings that the apostles received from Christ were handed down to the Church Fathers. Augustine of Hippo took the same position when he countered the British monk, Pelagius.[2] Pelagius rejected the doctrine of original sin and corruption of human nature that resulted from Adam's fall.[3] He undermined the doctrine of total depravity of human and further believed

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[2] Augustine, *Confessions*, trans. Henry Chadwick (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1985), 197.

[3] Erwin W. Lutzer, *The Doctrines That Divide: A Fresh Look at the Historic Doctrines That Separate Christians* (Grand Rapids: Kregel Publications, 1998), 155.

that man is morally capable to respond to grace. Pelagius strongly argued that man is not dead in sin but alive so he can choose grace without the aid of divine operation and intervention. A doctor of grace, Augustine abhorred his doctrine and shattered it into pieces. He wrote that human is not in a coma, but dead in sin; as a result, his will is in bondage to sin that innately chooses evil.[4] Only God can resurrect him up to life by renewing his will, as well as enable him to respond to grace. This is why grace is perfectly and purely God's gift, as he wrote, grace is the love and favor of God towards human beings. It is a favor that we have not merited, yet is made available to us. It touches the inmost heart and will of a person. It guides the lives of those called to be faithful.

In a nutshell, divine sovereignty plays one hundred percent role while human responsibility plays none in the work of salvation. Jonathan Edwards aptly puts, "You contribute nothing to your salvation except the

[4] R. C. Sproul, *What is Reformed Theology? Understanding the Basics* (Grand Rapids: Baker Books, 1997), 123.

sin that made it necessary."[5] This debate continued all the way to the Reformation Era.

DOCTRINE OF ATONEMENT AND GRACE IN CATHOLIC THEOLOGY

The full-fledged battle between *cooperative grace* and *operative grace* was fought in the Reformation Era. The Catholic Church did not deny the need of grace in salvation, what she denied was *Sola Gratia*! She claimed that salvation is the synergistic works of human and divine: God grants you grace and you must also earn merits by the righteousness of Christ until you come to the status where God makes you righteous.[6] To express this concept, they used the phrase, namely *the infusion of Christ's righteousness*—the righteousness that empowered sinners to do good deeds for salvation. In doing so, they rejected the doctrine of *the imputation of Christ's righteousness*—righteousness that counts sinners righteous without merits. It is the cooperative works

[5] This quote is famously attributed to Edwards despite lack of the original quotation in the primary sources.

[6] R. C. Sproul, *Faith Alone: The Evangelical Doctrine of Justification (*Grand Rapids: Baker Books, 1995), 163-186.

between grace and merits for salvation.[7] This is anti-*Sola Gratia*!

THE LORD'S SUPPER AND GRACE IN CATHOLIC THEOLOGY

The Church of Rome taught that grace is injected into the Lord's Supper. Sinners receive divine grace through the bread and the wine, thereby making the elements of the Communion the source of grace. This dogma not only lifted the Lord's Supper over Christ but also replaced Christ by bread and wine. This explicitly downplays the doctrine of grace and overplays the communion!

MARIOLOGY AND GRACE IN CATHOLIC THEOLOGY

Four 'I's plagued the teachings of the Roman Catholic Church: Immaculate Conception of the Virgin Mary, Infallibility of the Pope, Intermediaries of saints, and Indulgences. Mariology is the worst of all these doctrines that paralyzed the Catholic Church. Mary is believed to have earned extra merits than she required for heaven. She is viewed as a "reservoir of grace"! One can draw the

[7] Sproul, *Faith Alone (*Grand Rapids: Baker Books, 1995), 83-116.

water of merit from her if she is invoked in prayers. In addition, Mary completed the course of her earthly life and was assumed body and soul in heavenly glory immediately after her death to be the co-intercessor with Christ to intercede between God and man. All these teachings attacked and undermined the biblical doctrine of grace. In this way, the gate is opened wide to bring in all sorts of errors and lies of darkness into the Catholic Church.

SOLA GRATIA IN REFORMED THEOLOGY

The Reformation movement was in reality, the reformation and restoration of the doctrines of salvation which were clearly preached and taught by Jesus and his apostles. It is in accordance with the apostolic teachings and practices. Martin Luther, John Calvin, and Ulrich Zwingli condemned the doctrines of Rome. They viewed the Bible as the touchstone that tested every doctrine. All manmade traditions which did not align with the Bible were regarded as unorthodox.

The Reformers walked in the footsteps of Christ and his apostles. They argued that a human is a mere recipient of this divine gift, who plays no role whatsoever

in the works of salvation. Grace, however, is not free at all! Man received it freely but someone had to pay the big cost for it. It was Christ who paid the price in order to earn and merit grace for us. We received grace because of Christ's penal substitution on the cross. In other words, if Christ had not died on the cross, grace would never have been available for sinners. In reality, salvation is indeed by works but it is not our works, but the works of Christ upon which we put our faith for salvation (Rom. 3: 23-26, John 3:16). Sproul beautifully puts it this way, "the grounds of your justification are the perfect works of Jesus Christ. We are saved by works but they are not our own." Christ's atoning sacrifice expiated sin as well as propitiated, pacified, and satisfied God and his just demands of the law. In other words, the wrathful king is propitiated because the demands of his constitution are satisfied. The effect of this grand achievement of the cross is forgiveness of sins, justification, and reconciliation with God.

Christ not only *died* for our redemption, but he also *lived* for our righteousness (2Cor. 5:21). He died on the cross as our atoning sacrifice (active obedience) and

he lived a sinless life to fulfill the demands of the law for our righteousness (passive obedience) (Rom. 8:4). His active and passive obedience earned and merited grace for our salvation because he is both our vicarious sacrifice and our vicarious law-fulfiller (Rom. 10:4). All these accomplishments of Christ, according to the Reformers, have been imputed on the account of sinners and in return, their sins have been imputed on Christ's account. It is double imputation! By the virtue of the imputation of Christ's righteousness, God no longer sees our sinfulness, rather, he sees Christ's righteousness, thereby God declares us righteous without the works of the law. It is not God making us righteous by the *infusion* of Christ's righteousness, as the Catholic doctrine claims, but rather God declaring us righteous by the *imputation* of Christ's righteousness. The righteousness of Christ is the only cause and ground of our salvation. Good deeds therefore are the fruits of salvation, not the cause of salvation as Catholic theology taught. To express differently, good works are to empower us in our progressive sanctification, but not in our justification. Sanctification is a process while justification is the unrepeated definite act—the act

by which God moves a sinner from the state of sin (injustice) to the state of grace (justice). The so-called Catholic doctrine of "infusion" confuses justification with sanctification.

The Reformers also condemned the doctrine of transubstantiation and the Lord's Supper as a source of grace. Catholic teachings marginalized Christ by their improper emphasis on the Lord's Supper. The Reformers placed Christ in the center of their preaching, theology, and practices. The sufficient and infinite merits of Christ which he earned by his passive and active obedience, are the only source of grace. The so-called "treasure of merits", namely the merits of Mary, saints, and their relics are human inventions, imagination, and fabricated tales of the Catholic Church. In this way, the Reformers paid a huge price in so many ways and some even sacrificed their lives to redeem, revive, and rediscover the glorious doctrine of grace.

CONCLUSION

It is said that the Reformation happened in order to put back to the right position what was put upside down by the Catholic Church. This is true with regard to the

doctrine of grace. The Reformers not only rediscovered the glory of grace, but also corrected the doctrine of grace what was corrupted and abused by the Church of Rome.

Even today, there are groups in Nepal and India that teach things which can confuse believers about the true meaning of salvation. Some of them put too much focus on Old Testament traditions, even mandating the celebration of the Passover and other Old Testament festivals. These practices can raise questions about the sufficiency of the atoning work of Jesus Christ.

Other groups place too much importance on human traditions or church practices such as Mariology, the veneration of saints, and giving church the final word instead of Scripture. When traditions are placed above or equal to the Bible, the simple message of salvation by grace alone becomes blurred.

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Sola Gratia and the Hope of Healing: Pastoral Care for Youth Struggling with Drug Addiction in Sikkim

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Abstract: This article explores *Sola Gratia* as a source of healing and renewal for people battling drug addiction. It proposes that divine grace can restore hope, dignity, and identity as it goes beyond human effort. Grounded in both theology and pastoral care, the study shows how grace-centered ministry can offer compassion, support, and transformation for those struggling with addiction.

INTRODUCTION

In recent years, drug addiction among young people has become one of the most distressing concerns in Sikkim. According to the 2019 National Survey on Extent and Pattern of Substance Use in India, Sikkim is among the states most affected by cannabis (ganja, charas, marijuana, hashish) and opioids (narcotics, opium, heroin, brown sugar) use in proportion to its population, with rates high among youths.[1]

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[1] Atul Ambedkar et al., *Magnitude of Substance Abuse in India 2019* (New Delhi: Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, Government of India, 2019), 17-20.

The effects are devastating: families are torn apart; careers are reduced to mere dreams; and the mental, physical, and spiritual health of both individuals and families is deeply wounded. Depression, shame, guilt, anxiety, and loneliness become so severe that many go to the extent of even taking their own lives. In the face of such devastation, the haunting question arises: Is there any hope for those trapped in this cycle of destruction? The Christian answer is 'Yes!' because of the transforming power of God's grace.

UNDERSTANDING DRUG ADDICTION

NIDA defines drug addiction as "a chronic, relapsing disorder characterized by compulsive drug-seeking and use despite adverse consequences" and considers it a brain disorder because it involves functional changes in the brain circuits involved in reward, stress, and self-control.[2] The formal diagnostic term for drug addiction is substance abuse disorder. According to the Diagnostic and Statistical

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[2] NIDA, "Drug Misuse and Addiction," *National Institute on Drug Addiction*, accessed September 20, 2025, https://nida.nih.gov/publications/drug-brains-behavior-science-addiction/drug-misuse-addiction.

Manual of Mental Disorders IV, it is a maladaptive pattern of drug use to clinically significant impairment or distress, manifested by failure to fulfil major role obligations, physical hazards, legal problems, and social and interpersonal problems.[3]

From a biblical perspective, addiction is a demonstration of sin that separates individuals from God and leads to destructive behaviours. As Shaw rightly points out, "in the Bible, God addresses addiction as a sin nature problem and everyone since Adam and Eve, is born with a sin nature having potential to become physically addicted to chemical substances."[4] He sees addiction as a heart issue rooted in sin and defines it as "a worship disorder, where a person is worshiping and serving a drug or any substance instead of God."[5] Similarly, according to Welch, addiction is "a bondage to the rule of a substance, activity or state of mind which then becomes the center of

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[3] *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorder: Fourth Edition, Text Revision* (Washington, DC: American Psychiatric Association, 2000), 198.

[4] Mark E. Shaw, *The Heart of Addiction: A Biblical Perspective* (Bemidji, MN: Focus Publishing Inc., 2008), 10.

[5] Shaw, *The Heart of Addiction*, 11-12.

life, defending itself from the truth so that even bad consequences do not bring repentance and leading to further estrangement from God."[6]

When we consider both the psychological and biblical insights, it becomes clear that addiction is not just a medical problem, it is an intense spiritual battle. At its core, addiction is a manifestation of the heart's desperate search for hope, peace, and escape in all the wrong places. It becomes a form of bondage, where a person's dependence shifts from God to something else.

SOLA GRATIA AND HOPE OF HEALING

The doctrine of *Sola Gratia* which means "grace alone", is a central teaching of the Protestant Reformation. This doctrine arose in direct response to the Pre-Reformation emphasis on human works and rituals as a means of earning divine favour. It affirms that salvation comes entirely from God's initiative, not from human achievements or effort. Martin Luther's rediscovery of this truth in Romans 1:17 revealed that righteousness is

[6] Edward T. Welch, *Addictions: A Banquet in the Grave: Finding Hope in the Power of the Gospel* (Greensboro, NC: New Growth Press, 2011), 54.

not earned by human works but received through faith in Christ. Likewise, John Calvin emphasized that grace is the "free favour of God by which he reconciles us to himself in Christ," making clear that salvation begins and ends with divine mercy revealed in Christ Jesus. Alister McGrath notes that *Sola Gratia* was revolutionary because it relocated the source of salvation entirely to God's unmerited favour rather than human achievement.

In the pastoral care for people struggling with drug addiction, the doctrine of *Sola Gratia* provides transformative hope and healing because it recognizes the deep limitations of human strength. Addiction, as discussed earlier, damages human freedom and weakens the will, making it difficult for individuals to choose what is good even when they sincerely desire to change. Gerald May explains that human will alone is insufficient to break addictive patterns, yet grace does not cancel human participation. Instead, grace empowers the will, heals distorted desires, and restores the ability to choose life. Recovery, therefore, is not a matter of willpower or self-effort. It is the human heart learning to surrender and respond to God's initiating love. As May notes, healing

happens when the will cooperates with grace, not as an equal partner but as a humble receiver awakened by divine help. The pastoral response, therefore, must not only attend to physical and psychological needs but also to the spiritual condition that underlies addiction.

The experience of addiction often convinces individuals that they are beyond hope or help, trapped by shame and self-condemnation. As Dallas Willard rightly points out, God's grace meets people at their weakest moments with his power made perfect through their weaknesses. This understanding of grace reorients hope, focusing not on human effort but on God's sufficiency.

Therefore, *Sola Gratia* is not passive comfort but transforming power. Grace rescues, renews identity, restores dignity, and strengthens the will. For those struggling with addiction, this means that no one is beyond God's reach. Hope is not found in human strength but in the God who meets us in our weakness, lifts us, and makes new life possible through Christ.

IMPLICATIONS FOR PASTORAL CARE

Sola Gratia emphasizes that God starts, supports, and completes the process of change in our lives. This idea

influences how pastors can help people struggling with drug addiction. Addiction often reveals our weaknesses and shows that trying hard on our own is not enough. Grace brings hope when we feel we have lost our strength. Pastoral care shaped by *Sola Gratia* provides a compassionate approach to helping those battling drug addiction. It involves offering patient support, walking alongside them in their challenges, and believing that God can bring renewal even during tough times.

It first helps us let go of judgment and encourages compassion. Addiction is not just about making bad choices, it often comes from pain, trauma, and internal battles. Since God accepts us by grace rather than by how well we perform, pastors need to treat those with addictions with humility and kindness. We should not see ourselves as better, we walk alongside them. This approach fosters honesty rather than shame and opens the possibility for trust and healing.

Grace-centered pastoral care also recognizes that humans have limitations and relies on God's guidance. Addiction often leads a person to believe that change is entirely reliant on their own strength, which can result in

hopelessness when they encounter failure. However, *Sola Gratia* shifts the focus back to the idea that real change starts with God's assistance. Pastoral care, then, brings hope in God, which can inspire new desires, support those who are weak, and restore their sense of worth. Practically, this involves praying with people, encouraging them to trust God each day, and reminding them that they are never alone in their struggles.

Sola Gratia does not mean that we sit back and wait for people to take responsibility. We take action because God gives us the strength to do so. Pastoral care encourages people to take meaningful steps such as forming good habits, mending relationships, joining support groups, and seeking professional help when necessary. We assist individuals in recognizing their strengths, setting realistic goals, and getting involved with their community.

Finally, it teaches us that our worth comes from God's love, not from what others think of us. Pastoral care should help individuals recognize that they are not failures but human beings loved by God and that theyiij have the

potential to heal and grow. When addiction takes away our sense of value, grace brings back our identity and dignity.

CONCLUSION

The teaching of *Sola Gratia* is a source of real hope and healing. Grace is not about what we do but what God freely gives to meet us in our weakness and start restoring. Pastors who embrace this grace walk gently with those suffering from addiction, offering kindness, patience, and support to change hearts. Healing is a slow process with ups and downs but grace supports every step and restores the dignity and identity that addiction often steals. Through grace-centered pastoral care, people can find new chance of life, hope, and belonging because God's love is greater than any struggle.